

DEEP THOUGHT- AI BUSINESS ANALYST ASSIGNMENT

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PART A - Diagnosis: What is Actually going on

Situation A : The Alert Nobody Responds to

Stated Problem:

The CEO says he lacks visibility. Anil and Karthik say: 'We send the report everyday, we don't know why theft don't act on it'

What is actually going on

In my view, the problem is not that the company lacks visibility. The company already has trackers, dashboards, daily meetings, and automated alerts. The real issue is that the alerts are not connected to ownership, accountability, and action.

The alert email shows that a problem exists, but it does not clearly answer who is personally responsible for solving it, what action has already been taken, or what should happen next. As a result, the alert creates awareness but does not create accountability.

One thing that stood out to me is that the tracker assigns tasks to departments rather than individuals. When an item is marked against "Warehouse" or "Purchase," responsibility is shared across a group. Because no single person owns the issue, there is less pressure to come prepared with updates or solutions.

I also think the alert is highlighting problems that have already occurred rather than helping people manage work before it becomes overdue. The advisor noted that tasks are not broken into smaller steps, dependencies are not tracked, and daily micro-plans do not exist. If the underlying work is not planned and owned properly, an alert alone cannot drive execution.

Another indicator is that Anil and Karthik spend a large part of their week following up with departments. This suggests that the organization is relying on people to manually push work forward instead of having a system where ownership and escalation happen naturally.

Evidence from the Scenario

- The tracker shows department names such as "Warehouse," "Quality," and "Purchase" instead of individual owners.

- The advisor specifically pointed out that seeing a person's name creates accountability, while seeing only a department does not.
- The CEO stated that the same red items remain unresolved for several days.
- The alert email contains status information but does not show escalation history, ownership, or what changed since the previous day.
- The company does not have daily micro-plans for departments, making it difficult to identify and manage deviations early.
- Anil mentioned that most of his time is spent following up on commitments rather than building new systems.

Situation B: The Blank Field

What I Think Is Actually Going On

I don't think this is a discipline problem. What stood out to me was that the supervisors gave a completely different explanation from Anil and Karthik. Both supervisors said they avoid writing the real root cause because it creates problems for them later. One supervisor mentioned that writing the actual reason leads to a lot of questioning in review meetings, while another shared an example where a maintenance head was publicly called out after the real issue was documented.

Because of this, leaving the field blank is not carelessness. From the supervisors' perspective, it is a safer option.

The deviation tracker was probably created to help the company understand why problems happen and prevent them in the future. However, the people using it seem to view it differently. Instead of seeing it as a learning tool, they see it as something that can expose them or their colleagues to criticism. When that happens, people naturally become cautious about what they write. I also think Anil and Karthik missed this because they looked at the symptom rather than the experience of the people filling out the form. They saw blank fields and concluded that people were not disciplined. However, they did not appear to ask supervisors what happens after a root cause is recorded. If they had, they would have discovered that the issue is not the form itself but the fear of the consequences that follow.

Another thing I noticed is that this issue does not exist in isolation. The company already struggles with ownership, planning, and meeting effectiveness. If review meetings turn into discussions about who made a mistake rather than how to solve the problem, employees have very little incentive to document issues honestly. Over time, this creates a culture where problems are handled informally and the system contains incomplete information.

In my view, the real issue is a lack of psychological safety. People do not feel comfortable documenting the truth because they believe honesty may create personal risk. As a result, the company loses the very information it needs to improve its processes.

Situation C : The meeting that eats the day

Stated Problem: The daily status meeting is scheduled for 30 minutes, runs 60-90 minutes and leaves everyone with a pile of new unplanned work. Anil and Karthil say: ' Technical issues come up that we have to discuss'

What is actually going on

At first glance, this looks like a meeting problem because the meeting runs much longer than planned. However, after reading the scenario, I think the meeting is only revealing deeper issues in planning and execution.

The biggest clue is the advisor's observation that there is no daily micro-plan. The company has monthly and weekly plans, but people do not seem to have a clear plan for what needs to be completed today. Because of this, when issues are raised during the morning meeting, they immediately become part of the day's work. As a result, the meeting is not only being used for status updates but also for planning, problem-solving, escalation, and decision-making.

Another issue is that too many different types of discussions are happening in the same meeting. Technical issues such as OOS investigations, yield deviations, and machine-related problems are being discussed in front of all 12 department heads. While some of these discussions are important, not everyone in the room needs to be involved in solving them. This increases the meeting duration and takes attention away from other priorities. What stood out to me is that the meeting seems to be the only place where everyone gets visibility into what is happening across departments. Since the tracker does not show clear individual ownership and there are limited planning mechanisms outside the meeting, people bring more and more issues into that forum. Over time, the meeting becomes the central place where problems are discovered, discussed, and assigned.

I also noticed that Anil and Karthik spend most of their time after the meeting following up on action items. This suggests that the meeting is generating work faster than the organization can systematically manage it. Instead of focusing on building better systems, they are spending their days making sure tasks get completed manually.

In my opinion, the real issue is not the meeting itself. The meeting has become overloaded because it is compensating for gaps in planning, ownership, and execution management elsewhere in the organization.

Evidence from the Scenario

- The advisor directly pointed out that there is no daily micro-plan. The company has monthly and weekly plans, but no clear plan for the current day.
- The daily meeting was reduced from one hour to thirty minutes but still regularly runs for sixty to ninety minutes.
- Technical issues such as OOS investigations and yield deviations are being

discussed in the same forum as routine status updates.

- The advisor observed that the output of the meeting generates additional unplanned work for the rest of the day.
 - Anil stated that most of his time is spent following up on commitments, leaving little time for process improvement or system building.
 - Anil and Karthik were originally brought in to drive systems and cultural change, but their day-to-day work has shifted toward coordination and follow-up.
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PART B - Intervention Design: What I Would Actually do

Situation A: Making the alert actionable

Situation A: Making the Alert Actionable

The First Conversations: Listening Before Changing Anything

I would avoid starting with the CEO and COO. Instead, I would spend time with two or three HODs individually—ideally one whose department frequently appears in RED and another whose department is usually GREEN.

I would not start by discussing the daily alert email. Instead, I would ask them to walk me through a normal morning:

- How do you decide what to work on first?
- What information do you check before starting your day?
- How do you usually find out that something needs urgent attention?
- Do issues typically come from your team, meetings, or management?

My goal is to understand whether the alert is actually part of their daily workflow. From reading the case, it seems like the alert mainly helps leadership see problems rather than helping departments solve them. This is also supported by the fact that Anil and Karthik still spend a large part of their time manually following up with departments despite the alerts already existing.

My second conversation would be with the COO because he interacts with managers regularly. I would ask one simple question:

"When you see a RED item on the report, what do you expect to happen next?"

If the COO's answer is different from what the HODs believe should happen, then the issue is not technology. The issue is that there is no shared execution process.

The First Two Weeks: Changing Habits Before Building Tools

For the first two weeks, I would avoid introducing any new technology. My focus would be on improving ownership and communication.

Make ownership visible

I would work with Anil and Karthik to replace department-level ownership with named ownership wherever possible. Instead of "Purchase" or "Warehouse," the tracker would show the person responsible for moving the task forward.

I would present this as a communication improvement rather than an accountability initiative. The purpose is to make it easier to identify who can provide updates and resolve blockers.

Introduce a simple escalation habit

If an item remains RED for more than three days, the owner provides a short update covering:

- What is blocking progress?
- What actions have already been taken?
- What support is needed?

The goal is not reporting. The goal is to make delays visible early enough for the team to help resolve them.

Reduce unnecessary discussion

I would encourage the team to separate technical problem-solving discussions from routine status updates. If a discussion only involves Quality and Production, the remaining departments do not need to spend time in that conversation.

System Design: Automation Comes After Behavior

Only after the new habits become consistent would I introduce automation.

The system I would eventually build would provide each HOD with a simple department-specific summary instead of a company-wide report. Each person would see only the items relevant to their department along with any actions that require attention.

I would initially run this process manually so I could observe how people interact with it and identify any gaps in the workflow. Once the process becomes predictable and trusted, I would automate it using tools the company already uses, such as Excel and Power Automate.

My approach is simple: if people do not trust or follow a process manually, automating it usually scales the problem rather than solving it.

Getting Buy-In From a 15-Year Floor Veteran

I would avoid talking about accountability metrics, dashboards, or operational visibility.

Instead, I would focus on the problems they already deal with every day.

I would say something like:

"Sir, you've been running this floor for many years. You probably know which issues will become problems long before any report tells us. My goal is not to create more reporting or more meetings. I want to make sure the right people know about these issues early so that you spend less time explaining the same problem repeatedly and more time solving it. Let's try this for a week and see whether it actually makes your day easier."

In my experience, experienced operators are usually not resistant to structure. They are resistant to unnecessary bureaucracy. If they see that a system helps them solve problems faster and reduces interruptions, they are far more likely to support it.

Situation B: Making Root Cause Documentation Safe

The First Conversations: Understanding What Really Happens

I would start with the supervisors, not management.

Instead of calling them into a meeting room, I would spend time with them on the shop floor and ask them to walk me through a real deviation that happened recently.

I would say something like:

"Can you walk me through what happened when that batch issue came up last month? How was it identified, who got involved, and how was it resolved?"

I would deliberately avoid asking why root cause fields are left blank. My goal is to understand the actual process and experience before jumping to conclusions.

Once I have spoken to a few supervisors, I would meet with the COO and share what I learned.

I would explain that the blank fields do not appear to be a discipline problem. Based on the conversations, it seems that people are hesitant to document the full story because they are worried about how that information will be discussed later.

The supervisors in the case already provided examples where honest reporting led to uncomfortable public discussions. If people associate root cause documentation with criticism rather than learning, incomplete reporting becomes a predictable outcome.

The First Two Weeks: Building Trust Before Changing Forms

Before redesigning any tracker, I would focus on changing how deviations are reviewed.

Move active investigations out of large meetings

Ongoing investigations should be discussed only with the people directly involved in solving them.

The larger daily meeting should focus on updates and lessons learned from completed investigations rather than discussing unfinished issues in front of multiple departments.

Focus on systems, not individuals

I would hold a short discussion with HODs using real examples from previous deviations.

The conversation would be:

"What allowed this problem to happen?"

rather than

"Who caused this problem?"

In many cases, the answer involves missing processes, unclear ownership, delayed maintenance, resource constraints, or communication gaps.

Changing the discussion in this way helps people feel more comfortable being honest.

Introduce a draft root cause step

Supervisors would be encouraged to record an initial root cause within 24 hours.

This would be treated as a working hypothesis rather than a final answer.

The draft would then be reviewed privately before being added to the official tracker.

System Design

I would keep the process inside Excel because the company has already shown resistance to adopting new software.

The form would be simplified and focused on understanding the issue rather than assigning blame.

Field	Purpose	Owner
What happened?	Short factual description	Supervisor
Was a procedure available?	Yes / No / Unclear	Supervisor
Initial root cause	Best current understanding	Supervisor
Confirmed root cause	Reviewed and agreed	HOD
Corrective action	Action, owner, target date	HOD

Workflow

1. A deviation occurs.
2. The supervisor records the event and an initial root cause within 24 hours.
3. The supervisor and HOD review it privately.
4. The root cause is confirmed or updated.
5. Corrective actions are assigned with clear ownership and timelines.
6. Deviations that remain unresolved beyond the agreed timeline are flagged for follow-up.

Initially, I would keep most of this process manual. Once people become comfortable with it and the quality of reporting improves, I would introduce automation where it genuinely saves time.

Getting Buy-In From an Experienced Supervisor

I would not start by talking about compliance, forms, or reporting requirements.

Instead, I would focus on the problems they deal with every day.

I would say:

"Sir, you've probably seen the same types of issues repeat themselves over the years. What I'm trying to do is make sure that knowledge doesn't disappear once the shift ends. If we can document the real reasons behind these deviations, we have a better chance of fixing the underlying problem instead of dealing with the same issue again a few months later."

The message I want them to hear is simple: this process is not about finding fault. It is about making sure recurring problems are solved permanently.

Situation C: Reclaiming the Meeting and the Day

The First Conversations: Understanding Where the Time Goes

I would start with Anil and Karthik rather than management.

I would ask them to walk me through a normal working day from start to finish.

I would look at their task lists, follow-up trackers, WhatsApp conversations, and meeting notes to understand how their time is actually being spent.

Questions I would ask include:

- What work was planned at the beginning of the day?
- What work came out of the morning meeting?
- How much time is spent following up with departments?
- Which tasks keep getting postponed because something more urgent appears?

The goal is not to evaluate how they manage their time. I want to understand how much of their day is driven by planned work versus work that emerges after the morning meeting.

Once I have that information, I would meet with the COO and share my observations.

My view is that the meeting has gradually become responsible for too many different things. It is being used for status updates, project tracking, issue escalation, and technical problem-solving at the same time. As a result, discussions become longer and many people end up participating in conversations that are not directly relevant to them.

The First Two Weeks: Creating Structure Before Introducing Technology

Introduce a simple meeting triage process

At the start of every meeting, agenda items would be grouped into three categories:

- Routine updates
- Planned work updates
- Technical issues or unplanned events

Routine updates should be recorded quickly without discussion.

Planned work should receive a short status update.

Technical discussions should be moved to a separate session involving only the people needed to solve the issue.

I would personally facilitate the first few meetings until the team becomes comfortable with the approach.

Create a daily planning habit

I would work with each HOD to maintain a simple daily planning board.

The format would be:

- Three priorities for the day
- One expected risk or blocker

For the first few weeks, this can be done on a whiteboard, notebook, or simple spreadsheet.

The objective is to help people distinguish between planned work and genuinely unplanned work.

Protect time for process improvement

One observation from the case is that Anil and Karthik were hired to improve systems but spend most of their time following up on tasks

.I would work with the COO to reserve a dedicated block of time each day where they are not expected to chase

updates. This allows them to focus on analysing patterns, improving processes, and building long-term solutions.

System Design

Once the planning habit becomes consistent, I would introduce a simple shared planning tracker.

Each HOD would maintain three fields:

Today's Priorities	Unplanned Work	Why Was It Unplanned?
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The final column is the most important.

Over time, recurring causes such as vendor delays, equipment failures, missing approvals, or unclear ownership will become visible. This allows the company to address recurring problems instead of repeatedly reacting to them.

Workflow

1. Each HOD records their key priorities for the day.
2. The daily meeting reviews progress against those priorities.
3. New issues are tagged as planned or unplanned.
4. Technical discussions move to smaller follow-up sessions.
5. Unplanned activities are reviewed at the end of each week.
6. Recurring patterns are identified and converted into standard processes wherever possible.

Initially, I would keep the process simple and mostly manual. Once the team becomes comfortable with it, automation can be introduced where it saves time.

Technology Choice

I would use Google Sheets because it is easy to access, requires very little training, and can be updated from a phone.

WhatsApp can be used for coordinating follow-up discussions.

Power Automate can generate a weekly summary of recurring causes of unplanned work.

I would avoid introducing complex project management software because previous software adoption attempts have already struggled.

Getting Buy-In From an Experienced HOD

I would approach the conversation from the perspective of solving a problem they already experience.

I would say:

"Many days start with a clear plan but end up looking completely different because new issues come up during the day. What I want to understand is which of those interruptions are truly unavoidable and which ones keep repeating. If we can identify the repeat issues, we have a better chance of fixing them permanently instead of dealing with the same problem every week."

The goal is not to change how they work overnight. The goal is to make visible what they already know from experience so that the organisation can learn from it and improve.

PART C:Scale Thinking

What Breaks First When We Grow?

If this company grows from managing 2 active CDMO projects to 8, I don't think the tracker or the daily email will be the first thing to fail.

The bigger risk is that a lot of important information currently depends on a few people.

Right now, Anil and Karthik know what is happening across departments because they attend meetings, follow up with managers, and spend time talking to people on the floor. They know which tasks are genuinely blocked, which issues are likely to become bigger problems, and where teams need support.

This works when there are only a few projects running. But as the number of projects increases, the amount of information increases as well. A small group of analysts cannot keep track of everything through conversations and memory alone.

When that happens, communication starts becoming fragmented. Different people have different versions of the same update. Managers end up repeating the same information to multiple analysts. New team members take longer to understand ongoing projects, and important details can get missed because no one has a complete picture.

For me, that is the biggest risk as the company scales.

What We Should Build Right Now

Instead of building a complicated reporting system, I would create a simple Operations Learning Log.

The purpose is not to create more reporting. The purpose is to help the company capture and reuse what it learns.

Whenever there is a major delay, equipment issue, vendor problem, or process breakdown, it gets recorded using a few simple questions:

- What happened?
- Why did it happen?
- What was done to fix it?
- Did the fix work?
- What should be done differently next time?

Over time, this becomes a record of how the organisation actually operates.

The biggest benefit is that new analysts do not have to rediscover the same problems repeatedly. They can review past issues, understand recurring challenges, and become productive much faster.

It also helps leadership focus on patterns instead of isolated incidents. For example, if the same vendor-related issue appears repeatedly across projects, the company can address the root cause instead of handling each case separately.

What We Should Automate

I would automate repetitive information-sharing activities.

Examples include:

- Daily status alerts
- Reminder notifications
- Weekly summaries
- Lists of overdue items
- Trend reports

These tasks are repetitive and do not require human judgment.

Automation can handle them consistently and free up time for more valuable work.

Once the data becomes reliable, AI tools can also be used to identify recurring patterns. If the same machine, vendor, or process keeps appearing in deviations and unplanned work logs, the system can highlight it before it becomes a larger operational issue.

What Must Stay Human

Some parts of the work should remain human even as the company becomes more automated.

This includes:

- Root cause discussions
- Deviation investigations
- Conversations with supervisors
- Coaching managers
- Onboarding new analysts
- Performance and accountability discussions

The reason is simple.

People do not become more open because of a better dashboard or a new form. They become more open when they trust the people they are working with.

We already see this in the case. Supervisors were hesitant to document the real root causes because they were worried about how that information would be discussed later. That problem cannot be solved by software alone.

Similarly, new analysts will learn far more from spending time on the floor with experienced managers and supervisors than from reading reports by themselves.

My Approach

My approach is simple:

Automate information flow. Keep relationship-building human.

Technology should help the company spot problems faster, but people are still responsible for understanding those problems, solving them, and building trust across departments.

If the company starts building these habits now while it is still relatively small, scaling from 2 projects to 8 projects will be much smoother in the future.
